

BATTLE OVER GORSHKOV

An impasse over a former Soviet aircraft carrier now threatens defence ties between India and Russia

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

It was the biggest visible symbol of the longstanding defence ties between India and Russia. The hulking 44,000 tonne former Soviet aircraft carrier, gifted to India in 2004 for a token \$1 payment, is now the biggest symbol of a new defence détente between the two nations. The floating airfield, which can carry over 30 aircraft and helicopters, would have been a potent addition to India's surface fleet and a replacement for India's sole aircraft carrier, the 48-year-old *INS Viraat*. But with a new Russian demand for an unprecedented \$1.2 billion (Rs 4,800 crore), nearly twice the cost agreed at in the contract, and a revised completion date of 2012—a four-year delay—serious questions are being raised over the viability of this gift.

"Where is the relationship with Russia going?" a visibly upset Navy Chief Admiral Sureesh Mehta asked at a press conference. His pique was evidently reflected in the recent chill in relations with Russia, specifically over the refit of the *Admiral Gorshkov*. Mehta's outspokenness though was clearly not endorsed by the Government and the navy chief was ticked off for stepping out of line.

But the issue of cost and time overruns on the *Gorshkov* refit has been a major irritant in ties between the two nations which may not go away easily. It has not only figured in discussions between Prime Minister Manmohan Singh and Russian President Vladimir Putin and Defence Minister A.K. Antony and their state visits to Russia this year but numerous other defence delegations also have taken this up with Russia.

While there are currently arms deals worth over \$10 billion in the pipeline, over 70 per cent of the Indian arsenal is of Russian origin and hence



RUSSIAN STORM: The *Gorshkov* in happier days in the Soviet Navy

THE CARRIER CRISIS

THE DEAL: Signed in 2004 for \$1.5 billion for the carrier with 30 helicopters and MiG-29K fighter aircraft and a \$700 million refit in a Russian shipyard. Carrier was to be delivered by 2008.

WHY WE NEED IT: Critical component of blue water strategy. To replace India's only aircraft carrier *Viraat* when she retires in 2012.

THE TROUBLE: Russia cites dollar depreciation; asks additional \$1.2 billion to complete the refit. Can only deliver by 2012 instead of 2008 as per the Jan 2004 deal.

dependent on their support. The *Vikramaditya* is due to enter service in 2012 or 2013, an unprecedented eight-year-long refit for a 20-year-old warship that has already finished half her life, most of it as a derelict hulk.

The trouble began earlier this year when the Russian shipyard Sevmash in the Arctic port of Murmansk discovered that a part of the warship's wiring had been destroyed by humidity. The wires could not be removed or replaced without cracking open the entire insulation, a move that pushed up refit costs.

Russia later sacked Vladimir Pastukhov, the chief of Sevmash, but then in the talks last month inexplicably hiked the cost of the refit of the car-